

4.5 Something Old, Something New

Changes under Vista are not limited to the Explorer; new programs have been added, and new features added to regulars. Some have been dropped altogether, while others no longer enjoy a high level of integration with the operating system. Let's take a look at each of these programs separately.

4.5.1 Windows Sidebar

The concept of widgets has been around in one form or another wherever operating systems were to be found—be it the *nixes or the Windows, or indeed the Macintosh environment. Under Windows, specifically, this author recalls that Stardock had long ago introduced a concept quite similar to the now-prevalent Widgets. Vista introduced the Sidebar under the then-codenamed Longhorn build released in September 2002. While many have suggested that Vista borrows the idea from Konfabulator (now Yahoo! Widget Engine) or from Apple's Dashboard, it is interesting to note that both these programs were introduced after September 2002. What, then, is a widget? The simplest explanation is that it is a mini-program—one stripped to the most rudimentary features. For Vista's implementation of the widget concept, we can think of them as simple tools written in HTML/XML markup languages.



The Sidebar

The Windows Sidebar is a simple panel that gathers several of these widgets—which are called Desktop Gadgets under Vista—into a single interface element. The concept of the Sidebar originated from an internal Microsoft research in 2000. The Windows Sidebar is essentially meant to display quick information on various aspects of your social or online life. For example, a Gadget might be used to display RSS feeds off your favourite Web